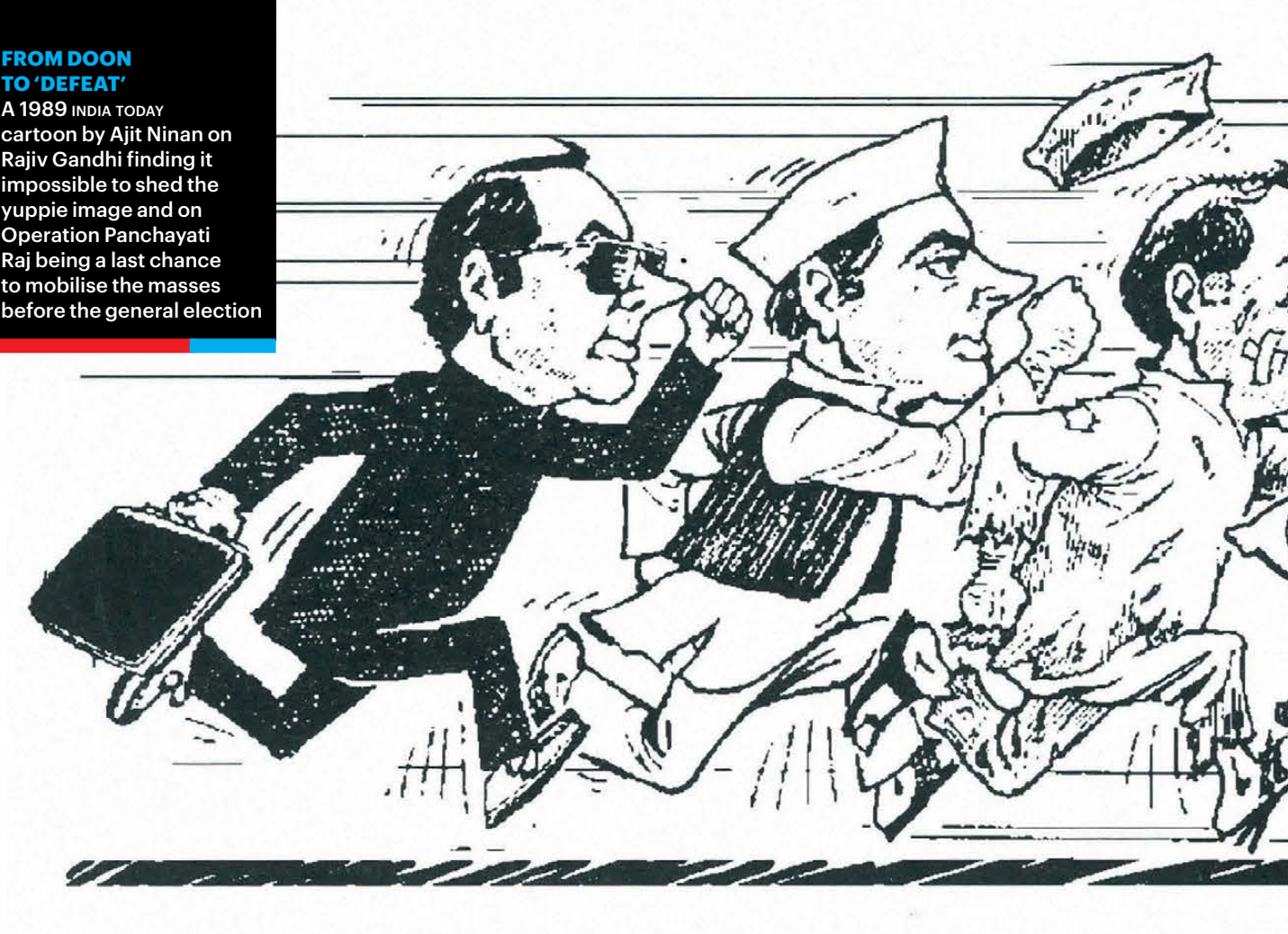


FROM DOON TO 'DEFEAT'
A 1989 INDIA TODAY cartoon by Ajit Ninan on Rajiv Gandhi finding it impossible to shed the yuppie image and on Operation Panchayati Raj being a last chance to mobilise the masses before the general election

SHARP TURNS

In a Republic still young and evolving, decades would naturally compete to be called the 'most consequential'. But even put to that test, 1985-1995 would probably have the most stories that dominate our democracy and debates today

By **SHEKHAR GUPTA**

At home and in the immediate neighbourhood, think terminal decline of the Congress after peaking, the first coalitions, Bofors scandal, the Mandal versus Mandir contestation, insurgencies in Punjab and Kashmir, two Indian military interventions overseas (Sri Lanka and Maldives), two war-like situations with Pakistan (Brasstacks, 1987, and with its first 'nuclear blackmail' in 1990), a fraught Sumduruong Chu stand-off with China (1986-87) and then thaw with Deng Xiaoping, assassinations of Zia-ul-Haq and Rajiv Gandhi, globalisation of Islamist (as distinct from Islamic) jihad and its spread to the Valley, and freeing of India's economy. Although it started as stable-looking as with a majority of 413 in Lok Sabha, the decade saw four prime ministers. Isn't that enough for a mere decade?

There's more. Because of economic reform, a globalising India's stake and stature in the world rose and just as INDIA TODAY became the most comprehensive and trusted chronicler of the change at home and around, its pioneering spirit now took its reader to the world. From the Afghan war, Tiananmen Square to the collapse of the Soviet Bloc and the first Gulf War following Saddam Hussein's occupation of Kuwait. The Cold War ended, as did apartheid, and India and Israel became friends. We were the first magazine to start sending our teams to cover the Olympics, Asian Games and key cricket series overseas.

For good news or bad, for generational shifts and eternal debates, the other decades would struggle to measure up. That all the fears India had had since Independence—political